delivers more than they thought capable. I am certainly questioning all this teamwork when, in one of the last tasks that involves someone needing to be on a stretcher, I'm carrying around Kevin Pietersen because he 'has a twinge'.

On the last night, the squad is made to circle each other, forming a man-made ring, and one by one, opponents are picked out to have a boxing match inside. It begins to unerringly resemble *Fight Club* as Tim Bresnan is allowed fair game to punch his captain, Andrew Strauss. Some land with the venom of a history's worth of ill-judged fielding placements he's paying for. Strauss lands back with the punches of a captain whose bowler has bowled shorter than a length he would have liked. Swanny and Cooky fight, hardly doing each other any damage whatsoever. I am finally picked out against Chris Tremlett. Tremlett is almost twice the size of me and as I face him, both fists held in front of my eyeline, the rest of the England squad turn into a pack of hyenas, laughing and taunting and begging for blood. I go into a little zone, an intense space of self-protection. Tremlett is stalking me. I try it all; bobbing and weaving, the odd combination, as good a version of rope-a-dope as I can fashion without a ring and ropes, trying to lean myself up against the pack of cricketers. He stalks me, taking one step for two of mine, preying on me. One gets through. It's a solid body blow, a right hand to my ribcage that, on impact, I absorb with a lengthening of time and feel an intake of collective breath, everyone wincing on my behalf. I won't find out until we get home that he's broken my rib.

On the last evening before we leave, we gather round the campfire. I hold my ribs tenderly, again the child who does not want to tell anyone that something might be wrong. I look up and around, everyone huddled together in different states of relief, some broken in body and some nearly in spirit, and it's as if all their faces look different to me suddenly. I can see all my teammates as they might have been when they were teenagers too – that moment on that bench, that time when I felt like the world had nothing to offer me, not putting their hand up to betray any pain.

Something very out of character guides me during this time around the campfire. Asked if anyone wants to say anything, I find myself, almost beyond my conscious will, standing up in front of the group. 'One of the things I've realised I really struggle with,' I begin to say, 'is how I deal with my emotions on the field, and if I could do that better, my skill and my